

The Architect's AI Playbook

Dennis Bottjer

45-Minute Practical Session



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Dennis “Mr. April” Bottjer

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Outside of tech, Dennis plays guitar in a band and co-runs a pizza review channel called Slice Snobs, proving that architectural opinions extend well beyond software. He lives in Tulsa, Oklahoma, and is a husband and father who enjoys good code, good security practices, and great pizza.

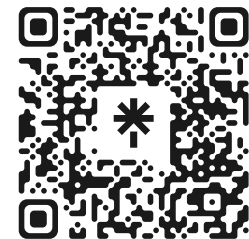
Focus

App / Solution Arch
AppSec, AI, C#, APIs
K8s, Vertical Slice

Awards

Former 3x MVP
Security Champ
AI Champ

Connect



01

Know the Game

Discovery: understand the system and verify the evidence

02

Check the Replay

Review: examine changes from multiple angles

03

Write the Match Report

Document: turn decisions into durable knowledge

04

Play by the Rules

Govern: make guardrails explicit and visible

05

Your Monday-morning playbook

Takeaways and Q&A

Aims and Outcomes

Role(s): Application / Solution Architects
or moving from Dev → Architect

Focus: Legacy Code / Modern Code

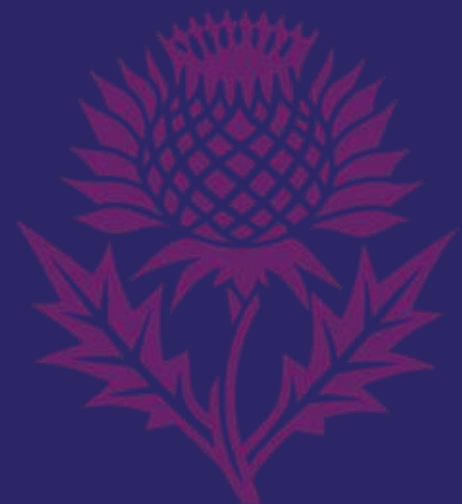
Tooling: GitHub Copilot

Space: Corporate / Enterprise Application
Development



“ How does AI improve our solutions? ”

The question behind this session





Where architecture work loses momentum

THE ARCHITECT'S REALITY

Discovery

Tribal knowledge and unfamiliar codebases

Review

Too many changes, too little attention

Documentation

Decisions decay after the meeting

Governance

Controls arrive late and create friction

Which one consumes the most time in your week?



Four plays for better architecture

THE ARCHITECT'S PLAYBOOK

PLAY 01

KNOW THE
GAME

Discovery

PLAY 02

CHECK THE
REPLAY

Review

PLAY 03

WRITE THE
MATCH REPORT

Document

PLAY 04

PLAY BY THE
RULES

Govern

AI accelerates the play. Architects own the outcome.

Know the Game

Play 01 • Discovery

Use AI to understand the system, form hypotheses, and verify the evidence.





Map the system before you make the call

KNOW THE GAME

1 Orient

Major components

2 Trace

Request flow

3 Probe

Dependencies and risks

4 Verify

Evidence and checks



Live demo: read an unfamiliar codebase

GITHUB COPILOT

DEMO FLOW

1. Explain the architecture
2. Trace one request (flow)
3. Surface risks
4. Show evidence

Do not trust architecture claims without evidence.



The map looks convincing, but evidence is missing

FLAG ON THE PLAY

Pause, inspect the evidence, then continue.

Invented architecture

Components or flows that are not present.

Stale context

Old decisions no longer match implementation.

False completeness

Unknowns are silently omitted.

Check the Replay

Play 02 • Review

Review changes from multiple angles without outsourcing architectural judgment.



Review the change from every angle

CHECK THE REPLAY

Intent

Does it solve the stated problem?

Architecture

Does it preserve boundaries?

Quality

Are tests and observability adequate?

Risk

Could security or operations regress?

AI expands coverage. Architects resolve trade-offs.

Live demo: review for architectural drift

GITHUB COPILOT

REVIEW AGAINST

Layering rules
Data handling
Failure paths
Operational impact

REVIEW OUTCOME

Facts versus assumptions
Prioritised questions
Human approval

Define the boundaries before asking for the review.



Separate findings from decisions / Separation of duties

PLAY 02 • CHECK THE REPLAY

AI SURFACES

Potential defects
Boundary violations
Missing tests
Operational risks

ARCHITECT RESOLVES

Severity and priority
Accepted trade-offs
Remediation
Approval or escalation



The replay becomes an automatic approval

FLAGS ON THE PLAY

Pause, inspect the evidence, then continue.

Volume ≠ confidence

Many comments do not prove material risk was assessed.

No accountable reviewer

Remaining risk has no named owner.

Delivery doesn't equal alignment.

Write the Match Report

Play 03 • Document

Turn conversations and code changes into durable architecture knowledge.



WRITE THE MATCH REPORT

DISCUSS

Teams and
meetings

DECIDE

Architecture
decision

CAPTURE

ADR

COMMUNICATE

Brief or
presentation

The artifact changes. The decision thread stays connected.

A useful ADR answers five questions

PLAY 03 • WRITE THE MATCH REPORT

Context

Why now?

Decision

What was chosen?

Alternatives

What else?

Consequences

What changes?

Ownership

Who revisits?

An ADR preserves reasoning, not just words.



Live demo: create the match report

GITHUB COPILOT

DEMO FLOW

1. ADR Skill
2. Readme Skill
3. Software Design Doc

The report loses the decision

FLAGS ON THE PLAY

Pause, inspect the evidence, then continue.

Consensus implied

The selected option is not recorded.

Alternatives erased

Rejected options and reasons disappear. **Note:** Beware of context pollution

No owner or trigger

Nobody knows when to revisit the decision.



Play by the Rules

Play 04 • Govern

Make guardrails explicit, executable, and visible throughout delivery.



Governance needs four visible layers

PLAY 04 • PLAY BY THE RULES

BOUNDARIES

Approved data, systems, tools, and prohibited uses.

CONTROLS

Checks embedded in prompts and delivery.

DECISIONS

Owners, escalation, and exceptions.

EVIDENCE

Sources, validation, approvals, records.

A simple governance operating loop

PLAY 04 • PLAY BY THE RULES

1 • DEFINE

Rules and boundaries

2 • GROUND

Approved sources

3 • VERIFY

Claims and tests

4 • DECIDE

Approve or escalate

5 • RECORD

Owner and evidence

Repeat when the system, policy, evidence, or risks change.



Know when to stop the play

FOULS TO WATCH FOR

Invented evidence

Components or citations that do not exist.

Unsafe shortcut

A plausible answer that weakens safeguards.

Rules left out

A valid answer that ignores constraints.

The Trust Model:

HUMAN ACCOUNTABILITY

AI ASSISTS

Explore context
Draft an answer
Compare options
Flag uncertainty

HUMANS REMAIN ACCOUNTABLE

Confirm scope
Verify evidence
Decide trade-offs
Accept, escalate, or stop

Accountability does not transfer to AI.

Put the guardrails in the prompt

PLAY BY THE RULES

1 • CONTEXT

System and evidence

2 • TASK

Analysis needed

3 • CONSTRAINTS

Policies and boundaries

4 • VALIDATION

How claims are checked

5 • OUTPUT

Reviewable format

Prompts expose rules. They do not replace approval.



Your Monday-morning playbook

TAKEAWAYS

1 Map one unfamiliar system

Verify the map.

2 Perform a review

State the constraints.

3 Capture one decision

Create and reviewed an ADR.

4 Make accountability explicit

Name the decision owner.

Better decisions. Faster.

AI can accelerate the path. Architects still own the destination.



Q&A and Feedback

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Prizes include a Dynamics Minds conference ticket, a Game Console, Lego, and Scottish Summit Merch!

Prize draw will be held at the Cabaret with winners contacted after the event.



Feedback wins Prizes!

Session Feedback

